Policy & Strategy Lab

Workbook 2: Structure and Causes

Participant	
Name	
Case (problem statement)	
Decision-making role and decision	
Pod	

How to use this workbook

Each worksheet applies one day's anchor tool to your own case. Complete it during the session and finish it in your independent time. Keep earlier versions: revision is credited, so record what changed and why in the feedback box at the end of each worksheet. Tag every substantive claim in your Analyst's Ledger as fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

Competencies practised in this workbook: B1, B2, B3, C1, C2, C3, C4, C5, F4.

Gate 1. This workbook ends with Gate 1. Submit the revised worksheets listed on the final worksheet, with a revision note and an AI-use disclosure.

Using AI tools. You may use AI tools to suggest structures, rival explanations or improvements to your writing. You may not use AI output as evidence. Every fact, figure, citation and description of an institution must come from a source you have checked.

Worksheet 2.1: Issue tree and sealed working answer

Day 3: Structuring with issue trees. Anchor tool: Issue tree (MECE).

Purpose. Turn your problem into a structured set of answerable questions, and commit to a first answer you will test.

In brief.

- A tree is only as good as its splitting logic. Name it.
- MECE has two tests: no overlaps and no gaps.
- Leaves must be questions that evidence can answer, not solutions.
- Write your best answer early, then try to break it.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). Madhyapur root question: why do most households hand over mixed waste? Level one, split by stage: households do not separate; collection mixes separated waste; separated waste has nowhere to go; rules are not enforced or rewarded. Each branch ends in two or three answerable questions (see the Day 3 slides).

Instructions.

1. Write your problem as a question at the root of the tree.
2. Choose a splitting logic for level one and test it for MECE.
3. Build down to three levels, ending in answerable questions.
4. Write your working answer in no more than 100 words and seal it.
5. Start your Ledger: tag every claim on today's worksheet.

Issue tree, level by level

Level 1 branch	Level 2 questions	Level 3 questions (answerable)

MECE check

Test	Pass or fail	What I changed
No overlap between level 1 branches		
No gap: every possible answer has a home		
One splitting logic per level		

Sealed working answer (no more than 100 words; submit separately)

My best current answer

My best current answer

Analyst's Ledger

Claim	Fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis?	Source or reason

Reflection.

1. What splitting logic did you choose, and why does it serve your decision-maker?
2. Which branch do you suspect matters most? Is that a hunch or evidence?
3. What would make your sealed answer wrong?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ Each level uses one splitting logic.
- ☐ No overlaps or gaps at level one.
- ☐ Leaves are questions, not solutions.
- ☐ The sealed answer is under 100 words and submitted separately.

Hand in. Worksheet 2.1 by the start of Day 4. Send the sealed answer to the instructor separately; it is not marked and not opened until Day 20.

Before the next session. Show your tree to someone outside the course and ask them to find a gap. Revise it. Add one more answerable question to your weakest branch. About 40 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why

Worksheet 2.2: Problem tree for your case

Day 4: Finding causes. Anchor tool: Problem tree.

Purpose. Explain why your problem exists, separating levels of cause and stating the mechanism behind each link.

In brief.

- Separate what you see from why it happens, and immediate causes from structural ones.
- Every causal arrow needs a mechanism.
- Five Whys and fishbones generate candidates; they do not prove anything.
- Most public problems have several causes. Single-cause stories are usually incomplete.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). Madhyapur core problem: most households hand over mixed waste. Proximate cause: separating seems pointless, because households see crews tip separated bags together. Structural cause: the contract pays by the tonne, not by stream. Effects: a near-full landfill, lost recyclables, unsafe work.

Instructions.

1. Write your core problem in the centre of the tree.
2. Place effects above and causes below; separate proximate from structural causes.
3. Write the mechanism on every link.
4. Run one Five Whys chain and check each answer against your tree.
5. Tag every cause as a hypothesis in your Ledger.

Problem tree

Level	Element	Mechanism linking it to the level above
Effect		
Effect		
Core problem		
Proximate cause		
Proximate cause		
Proximate cause		
Structural cause		
Structural cause		

Five Whys

Why?	Answer	Consistent with the tree? Evidence needed

Why?	Answer	Consistent with the tree? Evidence needed

Fishbone categories (optional)

Category	Candidate causes

Reflection.

1. Where in your tree are you most likely to be wrong?
2. Which cause, if true, could your decision-maker act on?
3. Did your Five Whys chain end on something you already believed?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ Symptoms, proximate and structural causes are separated.
- ☐ Every link states a mechanism.
- ☐ At least two independent causes are shown.
- ☐ Causes are tagged as hypotheses in the Ledger.

Hand in. Worksheet 2.2 by the start of Day 5, for inclusion in Gate 1.

Before the next session. Revise your problem tree after the challenge. For your two most important causal links, write what evidence would show the link to be wrong. About 45 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why

Worksheet 2.3: Causal loop and the Gate 1 diagnostic

Day 5: Systems and scope lock. Anchor tool: Causal loop diagram.

Purpose. Show what keeps your problem in place, anticipate the side effects of the obvious fix, and submit your revised problem diagnostic.

In brief.

- Look for the loop that keeps the problem in place, not only the chain that started it.
- Mark every link plus or minus; polarity is where reasoning errors hide.
- Every obvious fix has a likely unintended effect. Name it before someone else does.
- Your scope is now locked. From here the case can narrow but not change.

Worked example: Madhyapur (a stylised city; figures are illustrative). Madhyapur loop: crews mix separated waste, households see the mixing, households stop separating, more mixed waste reaches crews, and so on (reinforcing). Obvious fix: fines. Unintended effects: roadside dumping; a burden on small homes.

Instructions.

1. Draw one feedback loop that keeps your problem in place; mark polarities.
2. Write the obvious fix and two unintended effects it could have.
3. Revise your canvas, issue tree and problem tree using this week's feedback.
4. Write a revision note: what changed since Day 2, and why.
5. Submit Gate 1 with your AI-use disclosure.

Causal loop

From	To	Polarity (+ or minus)	Mechanism

Unintended consequences of the obvious fix

Obvious fix	Possible unintended effect	Mechanism	Who bears it

Revision note

What changed since Day 2	Why it changed (feedback or evidence)

What changed since Day 2	Why it changed (feedback or evidence)

AI-use disclosure

Tool used	For what	How you checked the output

A thinker for your case: Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock. Would the obvious fix copy the form of a programme that worked elsewhere without the capability behind it?

My answer, in one sentence

Reflection.

1. Would the obvious fix in your case copy a form without the capability behind it?
2. Which loop, if broken, would most weaken your problem?
3. What did peer review change in your thinking?

My reflections

Quality checklist.

- ☐ The loop has at least three links with polarities.
- ☐ Two unintended effects are named, with mechanisms.
- ☐ Canvas, issue tree and problem tree are revised.
- ☐ Revision note and AI disclosure are complete.

Hand in. Gate 1 diagnostic (Worksheets 1.2, 2.1, 2.2 and 2.3, revised) by the end of Day 5. Feedback returned by Day 7.

Before the next session. Catch up and rest. If you have time, identify the institutions responsible for your problem: which ministry, state department and local body are involved? Bring notes to Day 6. About 30 minutes.

Feedback and revision

Feedback received (peer or instructor)	What I changed, and why